

June 12, 2026

INFORMS Prize Committee
for the Teaching of OR/MS Practice

Dear Members of the Committee,

I am writing in strong support of Dr. Mohammad Dehghani's nomination for the 2026 INFORMS Prize for the Teaching of OR/MS Practice. I have engaged with his course IE 5374: Applied Generative AI from three perspectives: as a student in the summer 2025 cohort, as a Teaching Assistant for three consecutive semesters, and as a PhD student at Northeastern whose research focuses on generative AI in healthcare. From each of these perspectives, the course stands out as one of the most thoughtfully designed and practice-oriented applied AI courses I have encountered.

What distinguishes IE 5374 is that it is built from the ground up around a real-world application. Rather than treating generative AI as an abstract set of concepts, Dr. Dehghani structures the course around hands-on projects in which students build, deploy, and evaluate AI systems. As a student, I came away with the confidence to apply these methods in real settings.

The course is also remarkably accessible across academic backgrounds. Each cohort I have supported includes students from engineering, engineering management, data analytics, and adjacent fields, and Dr. Dehghani has designed the materials so that students with limited prior coding experience can engage meaningfully. Code is walked through step by step, and key portions of each example are intentionally left for students to complete on their own, a small instructional choice that produces a large effect on engagement and skill development.

The impact of this course is visible well beyond the course itself. As a TA, I have watched students complete IE 5374 and go on to participate in, and in several cases win, external hackathons in the months that follow, including students who began the term with limited applied AI experience. Dr. Dehghani reinforces this trajectory by changing the hackathon theme each semester, which forces students to transfer concepts to new problem domains, and by allowing them to propose their own final project topics, giving them real practice building an independent project from scratch.

Dr. Dehghani also goes out of his way to bridge the classroom with industry. In one example, he arranged for students to present their final projects at Google's offices, where Googlers gave direct feedback on the work. Beyond the technical critique, it gave students a window into a possible professional path, including the chance to meet Northeastern alumni now working at Google as software engineers and in related roles. Concrete connections like these are unusual in a graduate course and a powerful complement to the curriculum itself.

The course has also directly shaped my own research direction. The range of applied domains covered, from healthcare to industrial settings to operational classics like the beer game, gave me a concrete picture of how generative AI is being adopted across OR/MS practice. I am now planning to apply the methods and frameworks I first encountered here to my own PhD research on generative AI in healthcare. For these reasons, the genuine practice orientation, the accessibility across backgrounds, the demonstrated student outcomes, the active industry connections, and the way the course connects classroom learning to broader OR/MS practice, I offer my strongest recommendation that Dr. Dehghani be awarded the 2026 INFORMS Prize for the Teaching of OR/MS Practice. Please do not hesitate to contact me if I can provide any further information.

Sincerely,

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